



THAT MEN IN OUR KINGDOM SHALL HAVE AND KEEP ALL THESE LIBERTIES, RIGHTS, AND CONCESSIONS

THE SIGNING OF THE MAGNA CARTA (1215)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

**The development
of subjects' rights**

BEFORE

1100 Henry I's Coronation Charter promises to abolish unjust oppression.

1166 The Assize of Clarendon extends the power of royal justice at the expense of baronial courts.

1214 Normandy is lost at the Battle of Bouvines; barons bridle at the campaign's cost.

AFTER

1216 The Magna Carta is reissued on the accession of Henry III, and again in 1225 in exchange for a tax grant.

1297 The Magna Carta is again confirmed and written into statute law by Edward I.

1970 A bill repealing ancient statute laws leaves untouched four chapters of the Magna Carta, including Chapter 39.

On June 15, 1215, King John of England signed a charter at Runnymede, a meadow beside the Thames. Designed to make peace between the king and a group of rebel barons, the Magna Carta, as a form of the document became known, at first seemed ineffectual. However, its assertion of the rights of

subjects against arbitrary actions of the Crown—the essential principle of the rule of law—provided a blueprint which, more than eight centuries later, is still viewed as a fundamental guarantee of rights in the US and elsewhere.

Feudal society

When King John acceded in 1199, England was a feudal society, a land-based hierarchy headed by the king, who owned all the land. The tenants-in-chief (or barons) received land from the king in exchange for loyalty and military service. They in turn leased the land to their own armed retainers, who leased to peasants, or villeins. Yet monarchs, especially in England, were levying an ever-increasing series of taxes and additional financial burdens on their barons. English kings from Henry I (1100–1135) onward also sought to centralize administration, partly by establishing a series of royal courts. These royal courts raised revenue for the Crown through fines and charges—but at the expense of the barons, who had previously raised those funds from their own local tribunals.

The exactions of King John

The barons' discontent at these growing demands intensified under King John. Ruinously expensive campaigns against the French in 1200–1204 had already resulted in the loss of Normandy. Scutage, a further cash levy that left many barons in debt to money-lenders, was bitterly resented. Not only was the king proving lamentably unsuccessful in war, but he had